

Chapter 167-1

Liang Shi tried calling Chen Mian back, but Chen Mian had already turned off her phone.

With no other choice, she called Xu Qingzhu while heading out. "Are you about to get off work?"

"Not yet," Xu Qingzhu said. "I still have some documents to process."

After saying that, her voice became somewhat cheerful. "Are you already downstairs?"

"Not yet." Liang Shi got in the car, put on her Bluetooth earpiece, and started the engine. "I just left."

"Huh?" Xu Qingzhu drew out her voice and reminded her, "Then be careful on the road."

"Oh, when you come over..." Xu Qingzhu's words collided with Liang Shi's. "Babe, Chen Mian just called me and asked me to pick up Wanwan from a bar. I'm going to head over."

Xu Qingzhu paused on her end. After a moment, Liang Shi asked, "What were you saying just now?"

"Nothing..." Xu Qingzhu held back her request. "Did something happen to Wanwan?"

"You first." Liang Shi's voice carried a smile. "When I come to pick you up, what do you want? Let me guess... Hmm, do you want mango pomelo sago?"

Xu Qingzhu laughed on her end, answering brightly, "Mm, no ice."

"Got it." Liang Shi asked, "Anything else? Want a small cake?"

"You can buy one too," Xu Qingzhu said.

Liang Shi asked if she had any other requests. Xu Qingzhu thought about it but didn't have anything else.

The two chatted for a bit before hanging up.

Liang Shi told her she could take her time with the documents and rest if she got tired.

Xu Qingzhu laughed. "Who slacks off while working overtime?"

Liang Shi said helplessly, "You can't overwork yourself."

"I know," Xu Qingzhu said.

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Liang Shi arrived quickly.

This bar was more of a lounge bar. The style and music weren't too over the top. Since it wasn't peak hours yet, the bar's lights weren't flashing—they were just somewhat dim and dusky.

As soon as Liang Shi entered, she saw Liang Wanwan sitting at the bar counter with both arms pillowed under her head.

Chen Mian was standing beside Liang Wanwan, posture somewhat slack, looking down at her phone.

"Chen Mian." Liang Shi jogged over and called out to her.

Chen Mian put away her phone. "You're one minute late."

Liang Shi: "..."

"What happened?" Liang Shi glanced at Liang Wanwan, who was already passed out drunk, and went over to help her up.

Chen Mian didn't even make a move to help.

"She drank too much," Chen Mian said.

Liang Shi: "..."

"I know." Liang Shi couldn't help but retort, "I can see that. I'm asking why she got drunk. Was she bullied at school? Or was it something else? And you—what's going on with you? You said nothing was wrong, so why did you insist that I come pick her up?"

"You're her sister," Chen Mian said.

Liang Shi: "..."

"You can ask her about the rest." Chen Mian put one hand in her pocket. "After this, she and I won't be seeing each other again."

Liang Shi was surprised. "Did you two have a fight? Because of something at school?"

She did know that the two had been collaborating on something at school. Liang Wanwan had mentioned it to her once before.

"No." Chen Mian pressed her lips together lightly but still didn't explain.

Liang Shi found it strange, but she also knew she couldn't get anything out of Chen Mian. So she simply took Liang Wanwan and left first.

Chen Mian maintained her cold demeanor throughout, expressionless.

Even when they first met, she had been like this.

But today, she gave Liang Shi the feeling that she was deliberately avoiding something.

Later, Liang Shi noticed that from start to finish, Chen Mian hadn't looked at Liang Wanwan even once.

Liang Shi took Liang Wanwan home, then on the way to Xu Qingzhu's company, she bought mango pomelo sago and cake before picking up Xu Qingzhu. Downstairs, she also ran into Sally and Lin Luoxi, and incidentally... received their wedding invitations.

The date was set for Little New Year's Eve.¹

Liang Shi looked the two of them over and smiled. "Congratulations."

Sally patted her shoulder. "You have to come!"

People who were already married couldn't be bridesmaids, so both Xu Qingzhu and Liang Shi could only attend as guests.

On the way back, Xu Qingzhu put in a straw and held the cup as she drank. After walking for a while, she finally remembered to ask, "What about Wanwan?"

"Passed out drunk." Liang Shi said, "I put her in the guest bedroom."

"She doesn't seem like a kid who'd drink heavily. Did something happen?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Liang Shi shook her head. "I have no idea."

After a moment, Liang Shi added, "But I have a feeling it has something to do with Chen Mian."

Chen Mian's attitude was very strange.

After Liang Shi got home, she received a message from Chen Mian: 【Did Gu Xingyue make me hear "Flock of Lonely Birds"?】

Liang Shi hesitated, not knowing how to reply, so she set it aside.

But while she was chatting with Xu Qingzhu, her phone buzzed.

Xu Qingzhu thought it was hers and picked it up, only to see new messages from Chen Mian.

Chen Mian: 【Have you met Qi Jiao?】

Chen Mian: 【Was it Qi Jiao who wanted me to hear "Flock of Lonely Birds"?】

Chen Mian: 【Where did you see Qi Jiao?】

Xu Qingzhu read them aloud to Liang Shi.

Liang Shi had her reply: 【Qi Jiao passed away.】

But Chen Mian responded: 【Where did you see her? Take me there.】

1. Little New Year's Eve (小年): A traditional Chinese festival that falls on the 23rd or 24th day of the twelfth lunar month, about a week before Chinese New Year. It marks the beginning of the New Year celebration period and is traditionally associated with worshipping the Kitchen God. ↵